Classical Field Theory — Exercise Sheet 27

Matrix compatibility, formal charges and Bäcklund kinks

Questions only

The first two problems assume a smooth real KdV solution $u : I \times \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$, with I an open time interval, $u_t = 6uu_x - u_{xxx}$ and spatial period $L_{\mathrm{per}} > 0$. This is a conditional hypothesis, not an existence assertion on the circle. The last problem instead uses a real field on the whole line.

Exercise 27.1 (Converting the scalar KdV pair to matrices). For fixed $k \in \mathbb{C} \setminus \{0\}$ consider

$$-\psi_{xx} + u\psi = k^2\psi, \qquad \psi_t = -4\psi_{xxx} + 6u\psi_x + 3u_x\psi.$$

Set $\Psi = (\psi, \psi_x)^{\mathsf{T}}$.

(a) Eliminate higher spatial derivatives to derive $\Psi_x = U\Psi$, $\Psi_t = V\Psi$. Compute every entry of $U_t - V_x + [U, V]$ for an arbitrary smooth u.

(b) For the assumed periodic KdV field, state exactly what Lecture 27's monodromy theorem proves for these matrices. Does it establish the Poisson commutativity or independence of the resulting traces?

Exercise 27.2 (Local charges from a formal Riccati series). On a patch with $\psi \neq 0$, the scalar equation suggests $\rho = \psi_x/\psi$ and $\rho_x + \rho^2 = u - k^2$. In this problem work purely with formal Laurent series: put $\zeta = 2ik$ and seek

$$\rho = \frac{\zeta}{2} + \sum_{j \geq 1} a_j[u]\zeta^{-j}.$$

Equality means equality of each coefficient; convergence and a globally nonvanishing actual ψ are not assumed.

(a) Find the recursion and the first five coefficients. Integrate them over one spatial period and identify the first three nonzero integrals.

(b) Prove the formal identity $\rho_t = \partial_x[-u_x + (2u + 4k^2)\rho]$ under KdV. Conclude coefficientwise conservation. Explain which analytic conclusion about an actual spectral expansion has not been proved.

Exercise 27.3 (Bäcklund transformation and a sine-Gordon kink). On $\mathbb{R}^{1,1}$ use $\xi = (x+t)/2$, $\eta = (x-t)/2$. For two real C^2 fields $\phi, \widetilde{\phi}$, put $\alpha_B = (\phi + \widetilde{\phi})/2$ and $\beta_B = (\phi - \widetilde{\phi})/2$. For a fixed $a_B > 0$, the proposed *Bäcklund system* is

$$\partial_\xi \alpha_B = a_B \sin\beta_B, \qquad \partial_\eta \beta_B = a_B^{-1} \sin\alpha_B.$$

(a) Prove that any such pair solves $\phi_{\xi\eta} = \sin\phi$ and $\widetilde{\phi}_{\xi\eta} = \sin\widetilde{\phi}$.

(b) Put $\widetilde{\phi} = 0$ and solve for the branch $0 < \phi < 2\pi$ at finite points. Convert it to physical coordinates and find its velocity.

(c) For density $L = \frac{1}{2}(\phi_t^2 - \phi_x^2) - (1 - \cos\phi)$, compute the kink charge $Q = [\phi(+\infty) - \phi(-\infty)]/(2\pi)$, energy and lower-index momentum integral $\int \phi_t\phi_x \mathrm{d}x$. This line solution is not a periodic field for the monodromy theorem.